the centres of higher learning and developed their knowledge by mutual discussions and debates with renowned scholars. Not only that, there was also occasional summoning by a king to a gathering in which the scholars of the various viharas and universities would meet, debate and exchange their views.

Role of the Teacher

Teachers had complete autonomy in all aspects from selection of students to designing their syllabi. When the teacher was satisfied with the performance of the students, the course concluded. He would admit as many students as he liked and taught what his students were keen to learn. Debate and discussions were the primary methods of teaching. Teachers were assisted by their advanced level students.



The ancient Nalanda University was a centre of learning from the 5th century AD (CE) to 12th century AD (CE). Located in present-day Rajgir, Bihar. Nalanda was one of the oldest universities of the world and UNESCO declared the ruins of Nalanda Mahavihara a world heritage site. The new Nalanda University is envisaged as a centre of inter-civilisational dialogue.



Education in Medieval India

Medieval period witnessed a radical transformation with introduction of Muslim education in the Indian subcontinent. The country was invaded by various foreign rulers and several traders from different part of the world. The tradesmen and the invaders brought with them their own cultures and intermingled with the people of the country. Besides, religion, society and culture, education in medieval India also experienced a new perspective. The aim of education during Muslim period (medieval) was the illumination and extension of knowledge. In the eleventh century, the Muslims rulers established elementary and secondary schools. Education developed with a fresh aspect during that period as there was an excellent interaction between Indian and Islamic traditions in all fields of knowledge like theology, religion, philosophy, fine arts, painting, architecture, mathematics, medicine and astronomy.

However before the arrival of the Muslims in India, a developed system of education was already in place. Muslim rulers promoted urban education by bestowing libraries and literary societies. They founded primary schools (maktabs) in which students learnt reading, writing, and basic Islamic prayers. And secondary schools (*madrasas*) were established to teach advanced language skills. Several *madrasas* were set up by the Sultans, and nobles. The main objective of these *madrasas* was to train and educate the scholars who would become eligible for the civil service. Iltutmish was the first ruler to establish a *madrasas* at Delhi during his rule. Gradually many *madrasas* came into existence.

The system of education in medieval India was under the control of Ulema. During those days, education was related to religious training. However, various subjects such as medicine, Arabic literature, grammar and philosophy were also taught. History states that Arab and Central Asian people brought Muslim educational models to India in both the medieval and early modern periods. Women education in India was prevalent during the medieval period.

Raja Jai Singh of Jaipur encouraged learning of scientific subjects. Besides, many institutions were started by private individuals as well. Madrasa of Ghaziuddin in Delhi, and the *madrasa* of Maulana Sadruddin at Shahjahanabad.

In the later medieval era, the British came to India and introduced English education. With the coming of the European missionaries, Western education made firm advances in the country. Various universities and thousands of colleges were formed and popularity of education increased.

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